Handicapping Reference Guide

WORLD HANDICAP SYSTEM

R&A USGA

What's Covered?

This resource provides a high-level overview of the World Handicap System (WHS) and is intended to teach players the basics of handicapping. It's broken down into four sections:

GETTING STARTED	BEFORE YOUR ROUND	DURING YOUR ROUND	AFTER YOUR ROUND

GETTING STARTED

Purpose of the World Handicap System

The purpose of the WHS is to provide greater enjoyment for all who play the game by enabling players of any ability, from anywhere in the world, to play and compete with others on a fair basis.

With a maximum Handicap Index of 54.0, the WHS is inclusive and designed for all players.

What is a Handicap Index?

A Handicap Index provides you with a portable measure of your playing ability that's consistent with how golfers are measured worldwide.

It can be used to track your progress and play a casual or competitive round with any other player.

All players are encouraged to establish and maintain a Handicap Index.

How do I get one?

It's easy!

If there's a course in your area that you play often – get in touch with them.

Chances are they'll be able to set you up at the club on the spot!

The Allied Golf Association in your area can also help you find a club that meets your needs. A list of AGAs can be found at **usga.org/aga.**

Do I have to join a club?

Yes – but let us explain what we mean by "club."

A club can be public or private, as it just needs to meet the requirements to manage the Handicap Index of those affiliated for handicap purposes.

Every authorized club has a Handicap Committee who is there to help you. If you have a question or make a mistake while posting a score, reach out to your club.

I'm set up with a club – now what?

Go play! Just don't forget to **post your score** after you do!

Scores from match play, stroke play, and team formats where you play your own ball are acceptable – as long as you play by the Rules of Golf and another person is present during your round!

Before you post – check to see if any hole score(s) exceeded par + 5, which is the maximum hole score you can post during your first three rounds.

Once you've posted a total of 54 holes, made up of **9 or 18-hole scores**, you'll have a Handicap Index the very next day!

Your Handicap Index is the portable number you take with you but it's not the number you actually use out on the golf course.

BEFORE YOUR ROUND

Find your Course Handicap

Once you decide which tees you're going to play, it's time to convert your Handicap Index into a Course Handicap, which is the number of strokes you need to play to par.

Your mobile app may have the ability to calculate your Course Handicap for you.

For those of you who like math, you can do it yourself using the following formula:

Course Handicap = Handicap Index x (Slope Rating / 113) + (Course Rating – Par)

Set your Target

Your target score is the score needed to "play to your handicap." Since your Course Handicap changes from each set of tees, so does your target score.

Target Score = **Par + Course Handicap**

Course Info					15.0 Handicap Index Player		Target Score
Tees	Course Rating	Slope Rating	Par		Course Handicap		
Green	72.0	128	70	+	19	=	89
White	70.0	125	70	+	17	=	87
Silver	68.0	120	70	+	14	=	84

As you can see, when you play a more difficult set of tees, you'll be expected to shoot a higher score!

Know your Playing Handicap

If you're playing a recreational round, your Course Handicap simply becomes your Playing Handicap.

These numbers will often be the same, however, the Playing Handicap can be different when the format of play includes an allowance or if players are competing from tees with different pars:

Playing Handicap = **Course Handicap** x **Handicap Allowance**

Example: The recommended handicap allowance for Four-Ball Stroke Play is 85%, which means a player could have a Course Handicap of 15 and a Playing Handicap of 13.

DURING YOUR ROUND

Know where you get your strokes

Compare your Playing Handicap to the stroke index row on the scorecard.

The stroke index row identifies the order in which your handicap strokes are received.

Hole	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	OUT
Yardage	393	133	375	490	333	378	155	416	357	3030
Par	4	3	4	5	4	4	3	4	4	35
Stroke Index	5 •	17	9 •	1 •	11	7 •	15	3 •	13	
Player A										

Hole	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	IN
Yardage	341	152	360	131	471	323	314	375	340	2807
Par	4	3	4	3	5	4	4	4	4	35
Stroke Index	8 •	16	6 •	18	2 •	10 •	14	4 •	12	
Player A										

• Indicates where the player's 10 strokes are received

In this example, the player has a Playing Handicap of 10, which means the player will receive one handicap stroke on holes allocated 1 through 10.

Try your best and enjoy yourself!

If you happen to struggle on a hole during a recreational round, you don't have to finish it!

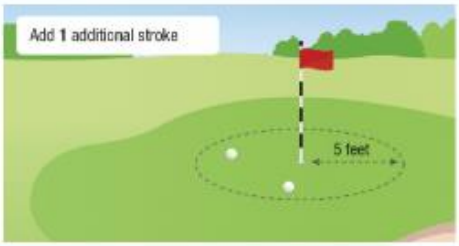
The maximum hole score for handicap purposes is **net double bogey**, so feel free to pick up once you've reached that limit!

Net Double Bogey = **Double Bogey + any handicap strokes you receive**

Example: A player with a Course Handicap of 10 receives 1 stroke on holes allocated 1 through 10. On a par 4 hole with a stroke index of 5, their net double bogey is 7 (double bogey +1).

Use your most likely score

If you don't hole out on a hole prior to reaching your net double bogey limit, then you should record your most likely score using the following guidelines:



AFTER YOUR ROUND

Adjust your score

1 If you did not play a hole due to construction, darkness, etc., you'll record a score of net par for any unplayed holes. **Net par is equal to par + any handicap strokes you receive.**

The minimum number of holes to post an acceptable score is 7 for a 9-hole score and 14 for an 18-hole score.

2 If any hole score(s) exceed your net double bogey limit reduce the hole score(s) to net double bogey.

It's recommended to post scores using the hole-by-hole option, which in most cases will apply the net double bogey adjustment automatically.

Post your score

Don't wait – Post your score immediately after playing!

You'll be expected to post your score the day you play because:

Your Handicap Index will be
UPDATED OVERNIGHT

and

Your score will be included in the daily
PLAYING CONDITIONS CALCULATION

Let the calculations begin!

At the end of each day, a **playing conditions calculation** takes place automatically, behind the scenes to determine if scores made at the course were **significantly** higher or lower than expected.

If scores were unusually low or high, a PCC adjustment between **-1 and +3** will be applied to your score differential calculation.

A negative (–) adjustment means the course played easier and a positive (+) adjustment means the course played more difficult.

A PCC of 0 means the course played as expected, which will be the case on most days.

Check it the next day!

Once the PCC is determined, your final score differential will be calculated – which measures the performance of your round in relation to the difficulty of the course played.

A score of 80 on a difficult course may be more impressive than a 77 on an easier one and the score differential calculation is what allows this to be captured.

Score Differential = **(113 / Slope Rating)** x **(Adjusted Gross Score – Course Rating – PCC adjustment)**

If your round is exceptional

If a score produces a score differential that is 7.0 strokes or better than your Handicap Index at the time the round is played, it is subject to an exceptional score reduction.

If the score differential is between 7.0 and 9.9 strokes better, your Handicap Index will be reduced by **1.0 stroke**.

If the score differential is 10.0 or more strokes better, your Handicap Index will be reduced by **2.0 strokes**.

Learn the basic calculation

A Handicap Index is designed to represent your ability when you're playing well – which is why you should be proud whenever you play to your handicap or better. You can typically expect to score about 2–4 strokes higher.

A Handicap Index is calculated by taking an average of:
Your best **8** score differentials out of your most recent **20**.

If your number is going up

Even the best players have tough stretches from time to time – and although form changes, a player's underlying ability does not change rapidly – which is why:

Each time your Handicap Index updates, the new value is compared to your Low Handicap Index from the past year and:

If a **3.0** stroke increase takes place:	If a **5.0** stroke increase takes place (after the soft cap is applied):
SLOW A **soft cap** will slow additional upward movement **by 50%.**	STOP A **hard cap** will prevent any additional upward movement.

The Handicap Committee can override the cap for circumstances such as injury.

Now that you can track your progress and play with others on a fair basis, you just need to enjoy yourself the next time you tee it up ... and don't forget to **post your score**!

If you have any questions, reach out to your local Allied Golf Association or contact the USGA Handicap Department directly.

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hdcpquestions@usga.org

To learn more, visit usga.org/whs

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https://www.usga.org/content/usga/home-page/handicapping/world-handicap-system/handicapping-reference-guide.html